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UAE merger to create fintech behemoth

DUBAI
BY JUSTIN VARGHESE
Your Money Editor

The largest digital payments company in the Middle East, Dubai-based Network International, and Abu Dhabi's Magnati, received regulatory approvals for their plans to merge.

This strategic consolidation will form a single entity, owned by a Brookfield-led consortium, with the merger process anticipated to conclude during Q3-2025.

This landmark union is set to create the largest fintech company in the Middle East region, boasting a combined Total Payment Volume (TPV) exceeding \$400 billion.

Vast network

The newly-formed powerhouse will serve a vast network of over 250 financial institutions, 240,000 businesses, and more than 20 million cardholders across over 50 markets within Middle East. For UAE businesses, this means an expanded and more robust local payment infrastructure.

The merged organisation will offer a comprehensive suite of solutions, encompassing digital payments, data and insights, small business lending, and advanced fraud and security measures.

Customers, ranging from small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs) to large enterprises and government agencies, will benefit from an expanded portfolio of tailored products and services.

SEE ALSO P5

Dubai airport world's busiest for international passengers

DXB RANKS SECOND GLOBALLY IN TOTAL PASSENGER NUMBERS BEHIND ATLANTA

DUBAI
BY ANUPAM VARMA
Online Editor

Dubai International Airport (DXB) has once again topped the charts as the world's busiest hub for international passengers.

In its latest report, the Airports Council International (ACI) said DXB welcomed over 92.33 million international passengers in 2024, a 6.1 per cent increase from the preceding year. London Heathrow (LHR) stood a distant second with 79.19 million passengers. Both DXB and LHR retained their rankings from the previous year. Incheon in South Korea (70.67 million), Singapore (67.06 million) and Amsterdam (66.82 million) wrapped up the top five.

In terms of total passengers (domestic and international), Atlanta continued to lead the charts with 108.07 million, followed by DXB. Dallas Fort Worth (87.81 million), Tokyo Haneda (85.9 million), and London Heathrow (83.88 million) ranked next.

Resilient aviation industry

The rankings are part of ACI's annual report, spanning passenger traffic, air cargo volumes and aircraft movement. "These rankings reflect the scale of global aviation and the resilience of the industry that continues to grow, despite the complex global environment," said ACI World director general Justin Erbacci.

Global passenger traffic hit a new high in 2024, surpassing 9.4 billion travellers — up 8.4 per cent from 2023 and 2.7 per cent above pre-pandemic levels

92.33m

international passengers welcomed by DXB in 2024

6.1%

increase in international passengers to DXB from previous year

5.5m

Indian tourists visited the UAE in 2024

11th

international passengers handled by London Heathrow, ranking it behind DXB

DXB's position globally in air cargo traffic, up from 17th

79.19m

108.07m

total passengers handled by Atlanta, ranking it on top



PHONE PAY: INDIAN TRAVEL TO UAE MADE EASY

Soon, Indians will be able to travel to the UAE with just a mobile phone in hand without the need for credit cards or cash, thanks to UPI integration, said Satish Kumar Sivan, Consul General of India in Dubai.

"The experience of Indian diaspora and Indian travellers to UAE will never be the same again after the complete integration of Unified Payments Interface (UPI — India's real-time, account-to-account payment system) with UAE's digital payments architecture," Sivan said during an event at the Consulate General of India, Dubai.

"Soon, we will be having a situation where Indian travellers would be able to travel to UAE with just their passport and their mobile in their hands," he added.

—Ashwani Kumar, Chief Reporter

(2019). The top 20 airports alone processed 1.54 billion passengers, capturing 16 per cent of global traffic. Of these, the United States contributed six airports to the top 20, mostly dominated by domestic traffic — except for JFK, where international pas-

sengers made up 56 per cent. Air cargo rebounded with close to 127 million metric tonnes handled in 2024 — up 9.9 per cent year-over-year and 4.1 per cent over 2019. The top 20 cargo hubs moved 52.2 million tonnes, up 9 per cent from 2023 and 10.8

per cent above pre-pandemic levels.

Key drivers of growth included maritime route volatility, which led shippers to seek more reliable and faster alternatives via air.

E-commerce acceleration, driven by consumer demand for faster fulfilment across borders, and falling jet fuel costs, which lowered operating expenses and improved air freight competitiveness, also contributed to increased air cargo traffic.

Here, too, DXB stood out as the biggest mover, jumping from 17th to 11th in the rankings.

Aircraft movements topped 100.6 million globally in 2024 — an increase of 3.9 per cent year-over-year, reaching 96.8 per cent of 2019 levels.

The top 20 airports saw 11.08 million movements, up 5.4 per cent year-over-year.

BUSINESS

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INDIA

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SPORT

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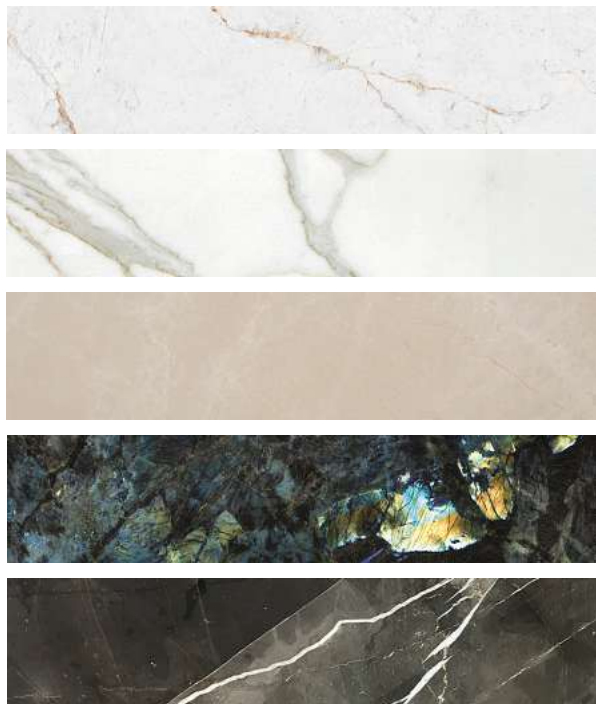


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